

Existence of God: the ontological argument

With the rise of scholasticism and Christianity's embrace of Aristotelian logic in the 11th century came a renewed interest in reconciling matters of faith with reasoned argument. One of the founding fathers of the scholastic movement was Saint Anselm, best known for proposing the so-called ontological argument for the existence of God.

Anselm asks us to imagine the most perfect being possible. If such a being does not exist, however, it cannot be the most most perfect possible and must be inferior to one of the same perfection that does exist. So, the most perfect being possible must exist – in Anselm's words, 'God is that, than which nothing greater can be conceived'. As a logical argument, however, this is flawed, and contemporaries such as Gaunilo of Marmoutiers pointed out that it could be used to prove the existence of anything. Later philosophers, notably Thomas Aquinas and later Immanuel Kant, showed that while the argument presented a notion of God's essence, it was no proof of His existence.



God is the
greatest thing
in the universe.



But what if God
doesn't exist?

In that case,
He's not really
that great...



So if he's really
the greatest
thing in the
universe, then
he *must* exist!